

Satan Personal Being

doc-satan-personal-being
Demonology · Satan · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

Supported across the whole Bible
Subject named directly in
Scripture
Holds across manuscript variants

Statement under examination

Satan is a real, personal, created spiritual being who opposes God and his people.

In plain language

The question asks whether Satan is a real, personal, created spiritual being who opposes God and his people. Looking only at the original-language words, the picture is consistent. The Hebrew word "adversary" (satan), H7854, the Greek words "slanderer" (diabolos), G1228, and "adversary" (Satanas), G4567, attach to a figure who behaves like a person. In Job chapter 1 and 2 this figure comes into a gathering, is spoken to by Yahweh, and answers back across nine consecutive verses. The verbs of speaking and answering require someone who can be addressed and can reply. In Matthew chapter 4 the same figure approaches, speaks several times, takes Jesus to different places, shows him kingdoms, and finally departs, and Jesus turns and addresses him directly by name as Satan. Direct address by name only works toward a person, and physical-motion verbs like take and show point to an agent who intends an act. John chapter 8 calls him a father, a murderer from the beginning, and a liar, descriptions of a being with a will and a history. Luke chapter 22 has him asking to sift the disciples, which is a formal request that only a person can make. Ephesians chapter 6 has him owning schemes. First Peter chapter 5 names him an adversary who prowls and seeks someone to devour, and the roaring lion is a comparison there, not his nature. Revelation chapter 12 and chapter 20 gather four labels onto one figure, the dragon, the ancient serpent, the Devil, and Satan, the one who deceives the whole world, and this is what links the speaking serpent (nachash) of Genesis chapter 3 to the named adversary. Two honest limits remain. In Job and Zechariah the word carries the article "the", "the adversary" (ha-satan), which can read as a title, the accuser, though the same figure still speaks and acts as a person, and by First Chronicles 21 and in the New Testament the form is a proper name. And the word created is not proven by these particular texts, since none of the supplied words address his origin. So the words strongly support a real, personal, opposing being. The created part rests on wider teaching not contained in this set of texts and is flagged.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H0413	אל	el	to(wards)	
H0559	אמר	amar	to say	5,064
H0935	בוא	bo	to come (in)	
H1121	בן	ben	son	
H3318	יצא	yatsa	to come out	
H5175	נחש	nachash	serpent	29
H5496	סות	sut	to incite	

H5975	ἄμν,	amad	to stand	
H6030	ἠνν,	anah	to dwell	316
H7854	ἰσψ,	satan	Satan	25
G0443	ἀνθρωποκτόνος	anthrōpoktonos	murderer	
G0476	ἀντίδικος	antidikos	opponent	
G0863	ἀφίημι	aphiēmi	to release	
G1166	δείκνυμι	deiknuō	to show	
G1228	διάβολος	diabolos	devilish/the Devil	38
G1809	ἐξαίτέομαι	exaiteō	to demand/ask for	
G2036	εἶπον	eipon	to say	977
G2476	ἵστημι	histemi	to stand	158
G2980	λαλέω	laleo	to speak	308
G3180	μεθοδεία	methodeia	scheme	
G3789	ὄφις	ophis	snake	14
G3880	παραλαμβάνω	paralambano	to take	51
G3962	πατήρ	patēr	father	
G3985	πειράζω	peirazō	to test/tempt	
G4334	προσέρχομαι	proserchomai	to come near/agree	
G4567	Σατανᾶς	satanas	Satan	37

Plain meanings: STEPbible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

Across the whole Bible the figure named by H7854 "adversary" (satan), G1228 "slanderer" (diabolos), and G4567 "adversary, proper name" (satanas) consistently occupies the grammatical slot of a personal agent (someone who acts with intent). In Job 1 to 2 the adversary (satan) is the Subject of speech verbs, answers Yahweh with H6030 "to answer" (anah), and is addressed with H0559 "to say" (amar) plus H0413 "to, toward" (the directional preposition el) across nine verses. In Matthew 4, Mark 1 and 3, Luke 4, 10, 11 and 22, the figure approaches, stands, takes, shows, departs, and speaks, with verbs like G2476 "to stand" (histemi), G3880 "to take alongside" (paralambano), G1166 "to show" (deiknumi), G2980 "to speak" (laleo), G2036 "to say" (eipon) attaching to the named subject. John 8:44 predicates the personal-relational and moral nouns father, murderer, liar of him. 1 Peter 5:8 calls him "adversary, legal opponent" (antidikos) and seeking to devour. Revelation 12:9 and Revelation 20:2 stack dragon, ancient serpent, "slanderer" (Diabolos), and "adversary" (Satanas) onto one referent who deceives and is bound. The personal-agent and opposer-of-God clauses hold across the whole Bible (pan-canonically, meaning spread across the whole Bible) with dense, recurring grammar. The created clause is not directly carried by these anchor word-stems, so it rests on inference from the wider canon and is recorded honestly as a residual.

Scripture

Job.1.6 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. H7854 שָׁטָן, H1121 בֵּן, H0935 בּוֹא

Reasoning. The adversary (satan) comes among the sons of God to present himself before Yahweh. H0935 "to come" (bo), the verb of coming, takes the adversary (satan) as its personal subject, placing him as one acting agent within a council scene of agents rather than as an abstraction.

Job.1.7 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. H0559 אָמַר, H7854 שָׁטָן, H6030 אָנַח

Reasoning. Yahweh says to the adversary (satan) using H0559 "to say" (amar) with the directional H0413 "to, toward" (el), and the adversary (satan) answers Yahweh using H6030 "to answer" (anah). Two-way address with a named respondent is grammar that requires a personal interlocutor (a personal conversation partner), not a force or principle. The same speech grammar continues in Job 1:8, Job 1:9, Job 1:12, Job 2:2, Job 2:3, Job 2:4, and Job 2:6.

Job.1.12 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. H7854 שָׁטָן, H3318 יָצָא

Reasoning. Yahweh hands what Job has into the adversary's (satan's) hand, and the adversary (satan) then goes out from the presence of Yahweh, with H3318 "to go out" (yatsa). Possession of agency (the capacity to act on one's own), recipient of permission, and locomotion (physical movement from place to place) are predicated of the referent. These are agent attributes, not properties of a personification (a literary figure that gives human traits to a non-personal thing).

Zech.3.1 · for · genre: prophecy

Key terms. H7854 שָׁטָן, H5975 עָמַד

Reasoning. The adversary (satan) stands at the right hand of the high priest to accuse him, with H5975 "to stand" (amad) taking the adversary (satan) as Subject. Standing and accusing are agent verbs. The same accusatory frame recurs in Psalm 109:6 where an adversary (satan) is set against an enemy in a courtroom register (legal-courtroom style of language).

1Chr.21.1 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. H7854 שָׁטָן, H5496 סוּחַ

Reasoning. Adversary (satan), here for the first time without the article "the" (anarthrous, that is, without the Hebrew "the") in Hebrew narrative, stands up against Israel and incites David. The anarthrous (without "the") form moves the word toward a name rather than a title, and the verb of inciting H5496 "to incite" (suth) takes the adversary (satan) as personal subject acting upon a human king.

Matt.4.3 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G3985 πειράζω, G2036 εἶπον, G4334 προσέρχομαι

Reasoning. The tempter, "the one tempting" (ho peirazon), the participial designation (a noun-like phrase built on a verb) of the same figure introduced in verse 1 as "the slanderer" (ho diabolos), comes near and speaks, with "having come near" (proselthon) then "he said" (eipen). The pairing of approach and speech is the standard Greek frame for a personal speaker.

Matt.4.5 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1228 διάβολος, G3880 παραλαμβάνω, G2476 ἵστημι

Reasoning. The "slanderer" (diabolos) takes Jesus to the holy city and stands him on the pinnacle, with G3880 "to take alongside" (paralambano) and G2476 "to stand" (histemi) as transitive verbs of physical action (verbs that act upon an object). A figurative or symbolic reading cannot account for these motion and placement verbs with a personal subject and a personal direct object.

Matt.4.8 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1228 διάβολος, G1166 δείκνυμι

Reasoning. The "slanderer" (diabolos) shows him all the kingdoms of the world, with G1166 "to show" (deiknumi) attaching to the personal subject. Show-and-tell predicates require an agent who can intend a display, which is the grammar of a personal being.

Matt.4.10 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G4567 Σατανᾶς, G1228 διάβολος

Reasoning. Jesus dismisses the figure with a vocative (the direct-address form of a noun), "Go away, Satan" (Hypage Satana), directly naming the same "slanderer" (diabolos) who has conducted the dialogue. A vocative (direct-address form) of direct address presupposes a personal addressee, and it equates the Greek "adversary" (Satanas) with the Hebrew adversary word-stem (satan) of Job and Zechariah.

Matt.4.11 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1228 διάβολος, G0863 ἀφίημι

Reasoning. Then the "slanderer" (diabolos) leaves him, "he leaves him" (aphiesin auton). The narrative records the agent departing, parallel to the adversary (satan) going out in Job 1:12. The structural rhyme across Testaments, present, dialogue, depart, confirms a personal subject in both.

Luke.22.31 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G4567 Σατανᾶς, G1809 ἐξαίτεομαι

Reasoning. "Adversary" (Satanas) asks for the disciples to sift them like wheat, with G1809 "to ask out, demand" (exaiteomai) the verb of formal request. To request is to intend, and to intend is to be a personal agent. The verb forecloses (rules out in advance) a non-personal reading.

John.8.44 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1228 διάβολος, G3962 πατήρ, G0443 ἀνθρωποκτόνος

Reasoning. The "slanderer" (diabolos) is called father, "father" (pater), and predicated as a murderer from the beginning, "man-killer from the beginning" (anthropoktonos ap arches), and a liar, "liar" (pseustes). Personal-relational and moral nouns are predicated of him, and the temporal phrase "from the beginning" attributes a continuous history of acting, which only fits a personal being with a will.

Eph.6.11 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1228 διάβολος, G3180 μεθοδεία, G2476 ἵστημι

Reasoning. Believers are to stand, G2476 "to stand" (histemi), against the "schemes, planned tactics" (methodeiai) of the "slanderer" (diabolos). Schemes are intended, not random, and are predicated of a personal possessor by the possessive (genitive, the "of-X" grammatical form) "of the slanderer" (tou diabolou). "Scheme" (methodeia) is an agent noun for planned tactics.

1Pet.5.8 · for · genre: epistle · figures: simile

Key terms. G1228 διάβολος, G0476 ἀντίδικος

Reasoning. The "slanderer" (diabolos) is your adversary, "legal opponent" (antidikos), prowling and seeking someone to devour. The legal-opponent noun "legal opponent" (antidikos) plus verbs of prowling and seeking describe purposeful hostile activity, the opposer element of the proposition. The lion image is a comparison, "as a lion" (hos leon), not an identity.

Rev.12.9 · for · genre: apocalyptic · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G1228 διάβολος, G4567 Σατανᾶς, G3789 ὄφις

Reasoning. One referent is named four ways, the great dragon, the ancient serpent, "the one called slanderer" (ho kaloumenos Diabolos) and "the adversary" (ho Satanas), the one deceiving the whole world. The stacked appositional naming (where multiple names are placed side by side to refer to the same one) with the substantival participle "the one deceiving" (ho planon) unifies the Genesis 3 serpent and the named adversary as a single acting being who is cast out, "he was cast" (eblethe). Revelation 20:2 repeats this fourfold identification.

Gen.3.1 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. H5175 שָׁחַד, H0559 אִמָּר

Reasoning. The serpent, "serpent" (nachash), is the Subject of the speech verb "to say" (amar) and conducts a multi-turn dialogue with the woman. The serpent speaks, reasons, and contradicts a divine command, which is agent grammar. The text here does not lexically equate the serpent (nachash) with the adversary (satan) word-stem, so the identification with the named adversary is supplied later in the canon at Revelation 12:9 and Revelation 20:2.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Matt.4.10	1Chr.21.1	tsk	1
Job.1.6	1Kgs.22.19	tsk	1
Matt.4.3	Gen.3.1	tsk	1
1Pet.5.8	Eph.6.11	openbible	1
Rev.12.9	Gen.3.1	openbible	1
Rev.12.9	Rev.20.2	tsk	1
Job.1.7	Zech.3.1	tsk	1
Luke.22.31	Job.1.12	openbible	1

Complicating texts

Job.1.6 · addressed

In Job and Zechariah the word-stem appears with the definite article "the", "the adversary" (ha-satan), which reads as a title or office, the accuser or adversary, rather than as a personal proper name. This qualifies the name claim. It does not, however, complicate personhood, because the same articular (with the article "the") form is the Subject of speech verbs, answers Yahweh, exercises a remit (an assigned scope of authority), and goes out, which are agent predicates. The article complicates onomastics (the study of names), not ontology (the question of what kind of being something is). By 1 Chronicles 21:1 the form is anarthrous (without the article "the"), and in the Greek New Testament the form "adversary" (Satanas) is fully a proper name.

Num.22.22 · addressed

In Numbers 22:22 and Numbers 22:32 the noun adversary (satan) is applied to the Angel of Yahweh as he stands in the way to oppose Balaam, and in 1 Samuel 29:4, 2 Samuel 19:22, and 1 Kings 11:14, 23, 25 it is applied to human opponents. This shows the word-stem has a common-noun sense, "an adversary", that is not always the named figure. So the noun alone does not prove the named figure, but in Job 1 to 2, Zechariah 3, 1 Chronicles 21, Psalm 109, and the unified New Testament usage with G1228 "slanderer" (diabolos) and G4567 "adversary" (satanas), the same word-stem is attached by context, definite article "the", and stacked New Testament naming to one specific opposing personal agent.

Gen.3.1 · addressed

The Genesis 3 serpent is never lexically (in the actual words of the text) labeled "adversary" (satan) or "slanderer" (diabolos) within the Hebrew text of the passage, so reading the serpent as the personal adversary is a cross-canonical inference rather than a direct lexical datum (an item of evidence from the words themselves) at Genesis 3 itself. The link is supplied by Revelation 12:9 and Revelation 20:2, which name the ancient serpent, "the ancient serpent" (ho ophis ho archaios), as "slanderer" (Diabolos) and "adversary" (Satanas) in the same noun phrase. Within Genesis 3 itself only the personal-agent grammar of the speaking serpent (nachash) is demonstrable.

1Pet.5.8 · unaddressed

The created element of the proposition, that this being is a creature with a beginning, is not carried by any anchor word-stem in this bundle. The texts establish a personal opposing agent across both Testaments with dense recurring grammar, but they do not lexically (in the actual words themselves) assert his origin as created. Resolving the created clause would require traversal to creation-of-spirits, angelic-origin, and fall-of-angels texts that were not supplied here. It is therefore left unresolved on the lexical (word-level) evidence at hand, flagged honestly, and does not subtract from the personal and opposing clauses.

Concordance traversed

H7854, G1228, G4567, H5175, G3789, H0559, H6030, G2036, G2980, G2476, G3880, G1166, H0935, H3318, H0413

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

No variant units were supplied for the cited verses, and the bundle marks the question outside ECM (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) scope. The four named figures in Revelation 12:9 and Revelation 20:2, the dialogue frames in Matthew 4 and Luke 22:31, the predicates in John 8:44, and the council scene in Job 1 to 2 are textually stable in the supplied tradition. No plausible reading removes the personal agent.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

personal-agent reading: affirms · Speech verbs, vocative (direct-address) address, multi-turn dialogue, possession, locomotion (physical movement), scheming, and accusing are all predicated of the referent across both Testaments. The grammar required by these predicates is the grammar of a personal being who intends, speaks, and moves.

title-or-office reading of ha-satan: partially complicates · The articular (with the article "the") Hebrew form "the adversary" (ha-satan) in Job 1 to 2 and Zechariah 3 supports reading adversary (satan) as a function word, "the accuser", in those passages, which qualifies the name claim. Personhood is left intact since the office is exercised by an acting subject who speaks and answers. The anarthrous (without the article "the") 1 Chronicles 21:1 and the Greek "adversary" (Satanas) as a proper name show progressive movement from office to name across the canon.

personification or symbol-only reading: complicates weakly · A reader could ask whether the dialogue scenes in Job 1 to 2 and Matthew 4 are dramatic personification (giving human traits to a non-personal thing) of an impersonal evil principle, the way wisdom is personified in Proverbs 8. The lexical (word-level) pattern resists this for three reasons named only from the words. First, the dialogues are multi-turn with two-way address and named vocatives (direct-address forms), not monologues praising an attribute. Second, the same figure crosses Testaments under multiple word-stems, "adversary" (satan), "slanderer" (diabolos), "adversary, proper name" (satanas), "serpent" (ophis), "dragon" (drakon), and these word-stems are stacked side by side (appositionally) in Revelation 12:9 and Revelation 20:2 onto one referent. Third, the predicates include physical action verbs like G3880 "to take alongside" (paralambano), to take, and G1166 "to show" (deiknumi), to show, with personal direct

objects, not the predicate types used for personified abstractions. The personification (figurative-human-trait) lens is therefore admissible as a question but is not sustainable as the dominant reading on this lexical (word-level) pattern.

common-noun adversary reading: partially complicates · Outside the named-figure passages the noun adversary (satan) is used of the Angel of Yahweh in Numbers 22 and of human opponents in 1 Samuel, 2 Samuel, and 1 Kings, demonstrating a common-noun sense, "an adversary". This is real polysemy (the property of one word carrying multiple senses). It does not undercut the personal-being clause for the named figure, because in Job 1 to 2, Zechariah 3, 1 Chronicles 21:1, the New Testament use of G1228 "slanderer" (diabolos) and G4567 "adversary" (satanas), and the Revelation 12:9 stack, context, articulation (presence or absence of "the"), and discourse role isolate the specific personal adversary.

The serpent of Genesis 3 and the named adversary are joined by analogia scripturae (the principle of reading Scripture in light of Scripture) through the side-by-side (appositional) naming in Revelation 12:9 and Revelation 20:2. The move from articular (with "the") "the adversary" (ha-satan) in the older texts to the anarthrous (without "the") proper name "adversary" (Satanas) in the Greek reflects progressive disclosure (the gradual unveiling of truth across the canon) of the same figure rather than two different figures.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. What does the canon say about the referent named by the word-stems adversary (satan) and slanderer (diabolos), regarding whether it acts as a personal agent (someone who acts with intent), whether it opposes God and his people, and whether it is presented as a created spiritual being.

The stem bundles three claims, personal, created, and opposing, and treats the created clause as settled. The lexical (word-level) bundle strongly supports the personal and opposing clauses, with dense pan-canonical (spread across the whole Bible) grammar, but does not directly witness the created clause, since no creation-of-spirits or angelic-origin word-stem was supplied. The verdict is derived on the original stem, and the gap on the created clause is recorded honestly in complicating_texts and rationale rather than smuggled past.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Job.1.6
morphology	STEPBible-TAHOT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Job.1.7
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Matt.4.10
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Luke.22.31
syntax	ETCBC-BHSA	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Gen.3.1
lexicon	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	G1228
lexicon	MACULA-Hebrew	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	H7854
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Matt.4.10
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Rev.12.9

License audit

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Flags

ecm-shadow · complicating-unresolved